support of newly formed Pakistan. Their initial progress was quick and largely unopposed. The remote mountain valleys were cut off from the rest of the world and even Hari Singh had no idea what was happening. The ruler only realized the seriousness of the situation when the invaders blew up Mahura power station, plunging the state into darkness. The tribesmen were just 75 km away from Srinagar, the capital. At this stage, they could just have driven down the short undefended and well-paved road and taken over. However, greed overpowered strategy and religious fervour. The tribesmen indulged in an orgy of rape and plunder where they spared neither Hindu nor Muslim. They also stopped to rape the European nuns of a Franciscan mission in Baramullah, barely 50 km from the capital. All this delayed their progress by a critical forty-eight hours.

The Indian authorities in Delhi first heard of the invasion from a very curious source. Remember that this was barely two months after independence, and the Commanders-in-Chief of both the Indian and Pakistani armies were British. The Commander-in-Chief of the Pakistan army was Major General Douglas Gracey who received secret intelligence reports of what was going on in Kashmir.[5] The first thing he did was to pick up his phone in Rawalpindi and call his Sandhurst classmate Lt. General Rob Lockhart, the Commander-in-Chief of the Indian army! It did not take long for Mountbatten and Nehru to find out what was happening.

Given the desperate situation, it was not difficult to convince a panicky Hari Singh to sign an Instrument of Accession in favour of India. By the morning of 27 October, Indian troops had secured Srinagar airport and were landing men and supplies. The tribesmen had lost the initiative and had been stopped at the gates of the city. Jinnah was furious. Bit by bit, the Indians began to push the invaders out even as the bitterly cold winter set in. It bears mention here that one of the heroes of the Indian side was Brigadier Mohammad Usman, a Muslim officer who had opted to stay with India. He would later be killed in battle in July 1948.

The first Indo–Pak war in Kashmir dragged on through 1948. Although Srinagar had been secured, western Kashmir, Gilgit and Baltistan remained in Pakistani hands. For a while, Pakistan even took over the strategically